

How can planning best cope with rapidly changing strategic environments such as we are currently facing?

Most traditional strategic planning begins with those involved attempting to develop a consensus on how the relevant strategic landscape will evolve during the upcoming planning period. Having agreed on this, decision-makers then develop the strategy they believe is most likely to bring success in that landscape. Unfortunately, in a time marked by convulsive change, there is often great uncertainty about what the future strategic landscape will look like in many areas.

Within DoView Planning, dealing with uncertainty is built into the way DoView strategy/outcomes diagrams are constructed. Rule 9 in the DoView Drawing Rules (B7) emphasizes ‘future-proofing’ DoView diagrams by including a broader range of strategic options than just those that are current priorities. This means that as conditions change, you can quickly adjust your strategic emphasis by shifting the priority of different boxes within the DoView (see Tool C1).

However, sometimes it is more effective to use formal ‘What-If’ planning, also called scenario planning. In this approach, you develop different possible ‘What-If’ scenarios as different DoView diagrams or as subparts of diagrams. At any point, you choose to operate on the basis of one or another of these ‘What-If’ DoViews, known as your ‘Current What-If DoView’. You then develop a set of ‘Switch Indicators’—these are indicators that, if they cross specific thresholds, signal that you need to switch to a different Current What-If DoView for your planning.

This approach complements Agile Planning and other short-cycle planning frameworks. Agile Planning keeps projects moving week-by-week; DoView What-If Planning ensures longer-term strategic coherence without requiring rigid five-year plans. By including different What-If scenarios in your suite of DoView diagrams, planners can quickly move to the new preferred DoView and use DoView tools like prioritization and Visual Alignment to ensure projects and activities are aligned with the new strategy which is best suited to the current environment.

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